Instrumental Helping Is Not Mature Altruism

In the second year, children sometimes help an adult complete a simple goal; this laboratory emergence is not mature altruism, a character forecast, or a parenting score.

ADE: MODERATE-EMERGENCE; LOW-CHARACTER-FORECAST | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: SOCIAL, BEHAVIOR | REPLICATION: VERIF

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Warneken & Tomasello (2006) showed that 18-month-olds often helped an unfamiliar adult complete simple failed goals (picking up an out-of-reach object, opening a cabinet) without being asked and without apparent reward. Chimpanzees helped in a narrower subset of the same problems. The object is instrumental helping in a laboratory, not a moral trait.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

Small-N laboratory experiments with a small set of goal types. Replication across labs exists for the basic helping act; interpretation as "altruism" is a further claim. Adjacent: committed-compliance-not-obedience.md is a different object (willing cooperation with a caregiver's agenda). Peer coordination (toddler-peer-interaction.md) is not this helping act. Sleep and attachment-intervention theory are not restated.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

Helping rates are high for some out-of-reach tasks and lower for others. Persistence as a trait is untested by this design. A child who does not help in one session has not been shown to lack a social mind.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a (laboratory behavioral task, not an observational population phenotype association).

Experimenter presence, task familiarity, and cultural expectations about assisting adults are live threats. Samples are modest and Western.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Instrumental helping is not mature altruism, conscience, or a parenting score. Failure to help is not a character defect. A helping trial is not an attachment classification.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Treat second-year helping as a developing competence, not a moral ranking. A kindness curriculum does not follow.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Warneken & Tomasello (2006), Science